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Keter Betts

Bassist Keter Betts is in demand at festivals throughout the country and for numerous record dates. He was born in Port Chester, New York and started as a drummer, later taking up the bass in 1946. He quickly became a sought-after musician and played in the rhythm sections of Cannonball Adderley, Earl Bostic, Dinah Washington and Woody Herman. He maintained a long relationship with guitarist Charlie Byrd and pianist Tommy Flanagan and recorded and toured with Ella Fitzgerald. He currently lives in Washington, D.C. where he performs in public school concerts in between his road engagements.

Keter was interviewed at the Sarasota Jazz Festival on April 11, 1996 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: Good morning. We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe. It's our great pleasure today to have with us bassist and avid golfer, Mr. Keter Betts.

KB: Good morning, Monk.

MR: This is the earliest interview we've done.

KB: Really?

MR: Yes. And for a jazz musician, not all of them like to be here this early.

KB: Well I feel as though the early bird gets the worm, and I like worms.

MR: Are you going to get a chance to get out on the course today?

KB: No, no. I just have a rehearsal at 1:30, so that sort of kills that.

MR: We should explain to our listeners that we are at the Sarasota Jazz Festival, and they have you working pretty hard here.

KB: Yes. It's not volunteer work. It's compulsory.

MR: Well we heard a good selection of tunes last night with Jazz at the Philharmonic. You come from an area of the country that I think probably offered some jazz opportunity when you grew up.

KB: Well I think one of the basic things that helped me was the school system, because I know in New York State and Pennsylvania and Michigan, they have, at least at that time, they had music in most of the schools, and this helps a great deal, those who want to be musicians because when we were in high school we had Harmony I, Harmony II, Theory I, Theory II, we had a marching band, we had a concert band, and there was tradition for an after school jazz band and those were playing Benny Goodman and Tommy Dorsey and Jimmy Lunceford and Count Basie arrangements. And they used to put on a play

so that was a great help and I was fortunately elected to be the director of the choir for the last two years, for just the high school. And I ended up being Class Musician. So this year, I came out in '46, and we're having our fiftieth reunion this year, and I'm looking forward to it.

MR: There's nothing like leading a group to really get some experience.

KB: Oh, yeah, very much so.

MR: And you started out on drums?

KB: I started out on drums, I was in the fifth grade. And we had an account at a little Italian store around the corner and my mother sent me to the store to get a loaf of bread and a bottle of milk. And an Italian parade came by. And I came back about four hours later with the milk and the bread, and my mother liked to kill me, because she was worried, you know, one block away and I was gone all over town following this. I realize now that it only takes a second for you to see something to impress you and then you want to investigate what is this, and I was following this parade all around town, fascinated by that. And so I did get a whipping, because — at least I could have come back and said Ma I wanted to follow the parade, instead of just going. But what I realize is that she — I said I want to play drums. After the whipping. "I want to play drums." So I guess she figured well if he takes a lickin' and keeps on tickin' he must really want to do it.

MR: You impressed the beat on the seat of your pants, right?

KB: So I started with a little snare drum. And there was a gentleman who used to come around the schools in the Port Chester area, he was a colonel in the Marines, his name was Paul Weckesser. And anybody that wanted to learn, he knew how to play most all the instruments, and he would show you how to hold sticks. Or if somebody went for the trumpet or trombone, he knew basic little things in there. And that was the start of it. And then I worked my way up to the first set I got was one with like we call a pool table with the coconut blocks on there, and I had that, and the moon on the bass drum and you know, put a light in there. And started playing Italian weddings and block dances and little parties after basketball games, and then worked my way up and I started studying in New York with a guy named Bill West. And he was somewhere around 46th and Broadway, somewhere in that area. And I would take lessons on Saturday, a half hour lesson, at 12:30. And so I would map out Friday night, who's at the Roxy, the Strand, the Paramount, the Capitol, the Apollo, and see who I wanted to see because I wanted to go see all the drummers. And I got to do that and it was fascinating.

MR: Well this had to be great preparation for your eventual career as a bassist I would think.

KB: Well I switched to bass through Milt Hinton.

MR: Because of Milt Hinton?

KB: Yeah. I'll tell you what happened. I was always watching every drummer. I knew that's what I went to see. And I saw Cab Calloway was going to be at a theater and I'd never seen Cozy Cole, because I tried to study with him but he was very busy, but I'd never seen him play, and I knew he was working with Cab so I said I'm going to go see Cozy Cole after I take my lesson. And I went to the theater, and a new drummer had just joined the band, and I didn't catch his name, and he took a drum solo and it was fascinating. And I said I've got to meet this guy, I've never even heard of him. So I asked the usher, how do you get backstage? And by the time I got back there he had left, you know, on their break, and I ran into Milt Hinton and we started talking. And I told him well I'd just graduated from high school last month and he said, "come on, I'll take you to lunch." And we started talking and I told him I tried to fool around with the bass in school and we didn't have many bass players, in fact we didn't have any bass players in school. I mean there was one guy who just picked it up and made noise. And I could hear all of this because of being in the chorus, you know, I could hear all those things. And he said "well if you ever decide to take bass, I'll give you the name of a good teacher here in New York." And I thought about it and I thought about it and a couple of, about a month or so later I went to this guy and it was Al Hall. And he was in the pits. He was like the first black player that, black bass player to get in the pits, and that was in 1946. So he told me he was very busy but he recommended a guy in Brooklyn. And so I called the guy in Brooklyn, and he said, "well come over," and I did. And then I decided, I think I will play bass. And I borrowed some money from mother and I also bought a bass, and two other guys started, we started the same time, Red Mitchell and Kenny O'Brien. We started with this guy in 1946. And Kenny O'Brien went on to go with Charlie Ventura, he was with Charlie Ventura, and Jackie and Roy, and Bennie Green, and Red was doing everything in New York, then he went out to California.

MR: It didn't take you too long before you started playing out.

KB: I was going out a year later. The next year I went down to Washington. A saxophone player from White Plains, Carmen Leggio, had been stationed down there in the service. And when he got out he used to go jam at this club. And the lady said, "if you can get a group together I'd like for you to come in." So he brought a drummer from Tarrytown, and a piano player from New Rochelle and myself. And we came down there, you know, green. First time away from home, we got out and the whole bit. And we came in for four weeks and stayed thirteen weeks. We were right around the corner from the Howard Theater and then around the corner was two other clubs, and Benny Golson was at Howard University then, and he was working at the club, and Ed Jones who later went on to Basie, and Charlie Rouse and Jimmy Cobb, and you know, the whole — so we spent

saxophone player named Rick Henderson called me in December to see if I could come down and do a month with him in January at a club down there, sort of like a supper club, and then Bostic came to town and heard me and asked me did I want to go with him, and that's how it went on.

MR: Now getting with Earl Bostic, was he doing straight ahead jazz?

KB: Rhythm & blues.

MR: He was doing rhythm & blues, so you got a new —

KB: I think the reason that I did that was the fact that I was going to get a chance to travel and see the country. You know, after studying geography, which you don't have in the schools now anymore, but after studying geography I said well I'll get a chance to see the country, it'll be a new experience, and it was. And at that time there was hardly no, you know like no freeways, there was none. In fact the only thing that you had was save for like the Merrick Parkway, there were a few of those around the country. The Pennsylvania Turnpike was like from 20 miles outside of Harrisburg to about 19 miles outside of Pittsburgh. That was it. And the rest of it, you went out to California it was 66, you know, the whole bit. But I got to see the country. And you'd be surprised at — I went in in April of '49 and in 1950 I got Jimmy Cobb with Bostic because Bostic needed a drummer and I recommended Jimmy Cobb. And we had to do a one-nighter with Dinah Washington in I think it was early '51. And she was just carrying a piano player with her. And so we had to do a set with her, a couple of sets with her, and she said, "listen, if you guys ever leave Bostic, you've got a job with me." And so we left at the end of '51 and went with Dinah. And the young piano player was Wynton Kelly. So here were are now, when I joined Bostic's band, I'm 19 years old, I'm the youngest guy in the band — no I'm 20 years old and the youngest guy in the band. And I went with Dinah a few years later, and I'm the oldest guy in the band and I'm 23.

MR: Boy, talk about starting on the top. Did you ever have any trouble with that particular group like traveling in different parts of the country?

KB: With Bostic?

MR: Yeah.

KB: Oh, everybody did. You know I mean that's the way it was.

MR: Kind of standard?

KB: It was standard, but I had not been exposed to that. I used to go down and sometimes spend a summer I guess I did it about five times with my great grandmother, who was in Wilmington, North Carolina, but I was too young to understand that because you know we never really had to go out from a certain area. And going down by train there was a Traveler's Aid, I think you wore a little button or something like that and you'd stop in

or something, and get to wash. They'd take care of you, you know. So when I went with Bostic, we would go out sometimes like three months, we'd do it sometimes twice a year — three month tour. And one-nighters. And there was an old man from Pittsburgh, no from Pennsylvania called Weinberg, and you'd do the Weinberg tour.

MR: He was the agent?

KB: He was the agent. And he booked from Washington on down, West Virginia, Virginia, North Carolina, South Carolina, that was all his territory. And you would go down to Florida, and then Rick Robey was the Florida area, and around to New Orleans. No Weinberg was from there. Rick Robey was in New Orleans and that area in there, and then you got up to Don Robey was in Texas and so forth. And sometimes we'd be in Texas three weeks. I mean that's how long it takes you to get out of Texas.

MR: Were these dances?

KB: These were dances, yeah. No concerts. And we finally went to California in 1950, and that was Bostic's first time there. And then went up to San Francisco and then up through [inaudible] and you'd come back the northern route where you would do Salt Lake City, Denver, Chicago and come through Ohio, and sometimes it'd be a three month tour.

MR: The whole country.

KB: Yeah.

MR: What was your first recording experience?

KB: With Bostic? A month after I'd joined him. And I got a featured thing. He had written this tune, I mean the arranger for "Wrap Your Troubles in Dreams" and the bass played the melody, so and the other side that he had was a hit so there was a lot of requests for that when we played the theaters. You know we were doing the circuit, the Apollo, and then there was the Earle in Philadelphia and the Royal in Baltimore and the Howard in Washington, and the Regal in Chicago. So when you made the circuit you made one, two, three, four, that's a month there.

MR: I read that Dinah Washington worked pretty quickly in the studio.

KB: Yeah.

MR: Is that right?

KB: Yeah, yeah. In fact I was telling somebody last night, we did one thing in New York and we had to do one take for — 29 takes for one song. But that had nothing to do with Dinah, it was somebody in the band, it was pitiful. Because she was very positive and because the trio, we had played these tunes so many times, we'd just go in, boom. We could run through it no more than two times and it's done.

MR: What was the pay scale for recording back then in the union?

KB: I guess it was according to the times of then it was supposed to be something. I can't even remember. I think maybe it was $150 or something. But at that time that was supposed to be, you know the equivalent of what it would be now.

MR: The recording scene in New York was pretty active, right?

KB: Oh, yeah. Very much so. Very much. Dinah was with Emarcy, which was subsidiary of Mercury. The P & R man was Bobby Shad.

MR: You worked with one of my favorite people of all time, Cannonball Adderley.

KB: Oh, now, there you are.

MR: How did that come about?

KB: I met him in New York and we became friends or something. And I left Dinah at one time, and he was going into the Cafe Bohemia, and he said, "well come on in, I'm going in for a month." And I said okay. And I went in for a month with him and it was Cannon, Nat, Junior Mance and Specks Wright out of Philadelphia, and myself. And then I went back to Washington, I had to go back to Washington, and so he said, "well can you recommend a bass player?" And I said well a good friend of mine is Sam Jones, try and get him, he's very good. And he got Sam and then Cannon started going right up the ladder, yeah.

MR: I think it's really fascinating how musicians recommend each other and they move around from group to group.

KB: Well you notice with Art Blakey's group that anybody was leaving, he'd tell them, "you get me somebody that's like you."

MR: That's how that worked.

KB: That's how that worked. He wound up getting young, good guys, and he would tell them, "if you're leaving, get someone." And Lionel Hampton would just go out and find them.

MR: Take them.

KB: Yeah, take them from someplace.

MR: And then when you went back to Washington you got hooked up with Charlie Byrd.

KB: Yeah. When I left Dinah, because my wife and I had a son and I said well I've got to try domesticated life. And so I went to Washington in October of '56 and I started working at a club that had just opened up in January and they had a house trio and they were bringing in names on the weekends. They brought in, the first one was I think it was Lucky Thompson, and then Art Farmer, and Donald Byrd, Gene Ammons, you know they'd bring them in for maybe one or two weekends. And they went down the list of all these different people. And I stayed there for six months and a guy offered me more money and a better job with better conditions up on Connecticut Avenue and I went up there, and that's how we hooked up with Charlie. And we worked at this club for about

intermission. And the deal went down with whoever was in charge at that club, so they were looking at another club and he said, "well look I have a little restaurant up on 18th and Columbia Road, why don't you work with the trio up there and you can get back together for that" pending that this big club was going to open. And the deal fell through, and by that time we were starting to build up something going up there, so then we just stayed there. And then it just kept on escalating and getting better and better. And we went to Europe with Woody Herman in '59, and that was, he took over seven pieces and added nine British musicians, and that was the first, they called the first Anglo Saxon band to tour the states. There was Jimmy Campbell on drums, Vince Guaraldi on piano, Bill Harris on trombone, and Nat Adderley and Charlie Byrd and myself. And we picked up nine British musicians and we rehearsed for two days and we went out and toured England for three weeks. We never got back to London for three weeks. And we never saw the sun for three weeks. Never saw the sun until the day we got back into London and the sun came out, and there was people sitting in Hyde Park with their faces just looking at the sun, because they hadn't seen the sun. And then two days later with the small group we went to Saudi Arabia for the Aramco people. That's all we saw for eight days, pure sun, no clouds, pure sun.

MR: That's great you got to see, you know, a good part of the world.

KB: Oh, yeah, yeah.

MR: And you've probably been to Japan also?

KB: Oh, yes, yes, yes.

MR: More recently perhaps?

KB: In fact I was just there, last time I was there was about five years ago I think it was for the Concord Jazz Festival, but I went over there with Ella two times, two, three times.

MR: When you're working with a guitar trio, that gives you a lot more room to be a like major soloist almost.

KB: It does. And also it gives you a lot of room to learn A E B and D and all of those strings that the guitar players love.

MR: They like the sharps, don't they.

KB: Yeah.

MR: I guess that like if you look around if you see horn players you know, well I'm going to be doing certain keys.

KB: Oh, yeah, yeah.

MR: Let me back track just a little bit. When you were first learning the bass, in addition to learning the technique of it, what was the — how did you learn the jazz repertory? Was it just picking up music from your teacher?

KB: No, no, no. Because the teacher there was strictly classical. And he would have, even when Red would come in, the first thing he would do is have you play, he'd say, "just play me one chorus of 'Body and Soul.'" And you know he'd say I just don't understand how you do that. Because you use the imagination. See the difference between — the fine line between that is if you're studying classical, strictly classical, you are actually taught to play what you see. In other words what is written out, you play what you see. So you become, this is your guide. And when you're playing jazz, I mean if you're not reading something, you have to play what you think. So it's the complete opposite. You have to think. And then when it comes to solos, that's when you can tell good soloists and bad soloists is how well they think. I show students, when you really get down to the nitty gritty part of it is the fact that you're learning the instrument, you're trying to learn the instrument to a certain point as well as you know your body. In other words, let's say if you were itching, and you had something in your hand and you were itching on the shoulder, you would say, "Keter, scratch on my shoulder." And you say, "no, no, a little further over, a little further down." But now if you could do it you could put your hand right on it. So this is the way that you approach the bass, that you put your hand right on what you hear in your mind, if you hear it. And then you'll find out that you're actually, I mean when you're standing there with the bass, it looks like two things, but it's really one because of the fact that it's a person's mind that's coming out of the instrument. So consequently what is happening is the person is not playing the instrument, he's playing themself. Because you go inside the instrument and you play out.

MR: That's a great way to say it.

KB: It's not too heavy for you this early in the morning, is it?

MR: No, I like it. I might have to listen to it again later to make sure I got it all man.

KB: Okay.

MR: I really like it when a musician seems to — what they're thinking seems to connect with the audience. Like last night when you were doing a solo and — I can't remember which tune it was — and you were doing a sliding —

KB: Oh, yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: And when you got about into the fourth measure, people, I could tell people were like with you. They thought they knew what you were going to do. And you almost did it, except that you would change it a little bit. But you could feel it around me, like yeah, I like this thing he's doing.

KB: Well you're playing for the public, I mean you're playing for yourself, you're playing for the musicians but you're playing for the public because these are the ones who came to see you. And you take your ability, what you have, and utilize it to the best that you can.

know it's like writing a book or some novel. I mean everybody knows words, but it's how good an author can put these words together to make it interesting.

MR: Cannonball had a particular philosophy on that too. I just read an article about him and he was saying how it's kind of a balance between keeping your own originality but you're playing for the public and you're there to please them.

KB: Well, one of the things that I've found over the course of the years with all of the traveling that I've done throughout the world is that music is a language within itself. And when you forget about speaking words, which English is here and there and there is all other different languages, but the music itself has its own language that people understand and comprehend — if they like it or if it's good. And I think that when you speak music, and you speak music from your mind, people understand it. Your mouth can be running a mile a minute, if you're not saying nothing, it doesn't mean nothing. But if you're speaking music, then, because your whole purpose is to make people happy and make yourself happy too. So I consider it to a certain point, as they say, if they have the gods to give you talent of whatever field that you're in, and so when you're taking a solo it's like you're saying a little prayer, thanking Him for the ability to be able to do this. Make sense?

MR: Yeah.

KB: Not too heavy for you this early in the morning?

MR: I'm warming up.

KB: Okay.

MR: How did the association with Tommy Flanagan and Ella come about?

KB: I stayed with Charlie Byrd until June of '64 in Washington, and then I went into the Caverns with Bobby Timmons for three months. And Ray Brown came in and Ray and I have been good friends going back with Herb Ellis and back when I was with Dinah. And whenever they'd come to Washington I used to have them over for dinner, fix dinner for them. So he said, "Ella's going to need a bass player, would you like to go with her?" And I said, "well okay," so I went the first time in '64. And I stayed a year. And then she usually takes a three month vacation, July and August and start like September or October. At this time this friend of mine in Washington had opened up this club and the day that I got home he called me that night and said, "what are you doing?" I said, "I just got back in town and I'll be here for about three months." He said, "my bass player is sick, could you come work at the club?" And I said, "okay, when?" And he said, "starting tomorrow." And I went in there, and it was like a house group and they were more like Dixieland and he was bringing in various people, Wild Bill Davison and Peanuts Hucko and his wife, and you can go down the list, Pee Wee Russell, Charlie Shavers, Roy

then there was a T.V. show that I would do five days a week with Mark Russell, the comedian, the politician comedian, "The Mark and Ginger Show" so I decided not to go back with Ella because by this time we had three children and I wanted to buy a house. So we stayed there and bought the house.

MR: But you stuck with Tommy Flanagan for a number of years.

KB: Well when I went with Ella, when first I went with Ella, Tommy was with her, and then when I went back in '71, Tommy was with her, Tom and Ed Thigpen. And Ed left in '72 because he had married and his wife had a baby, and they got — Bobby Durham I think it was. Yeah. And so I was Tommy, Tommy and me stayed until '76. Almost five years with Tommy during that period there. Yeah, '76 he left.

MR: Does your family enjoy the kind of lifestyle and the kind of music you do?

KB: Who knows? No they've been very supportive. I mean the kids have their own type of things, but they've come out to a lot of places that I was working at and — oh I was wrong, Tommy Flanagan left in '78 because I remember we did the Montreaux in '77. But that was one experience. Think of in your lifetime, just in the short amount of time you're working with Wynton Kelly and of course Wynton had to go to the Army. I'm back tracking back to Dinah when I joined in '51, and then in the middle of '52, not quite the middle, he had to go to the Army so we got Beryl Booker down there, Beryl Booker, and she was for a while and then we had a piano player out of Chicago named Sleepy Anderson for a while, then Junior Mance went with Dinah for a while, and then when I went with Ella there was Tommy Flanagan and that puts something in your mind.

MR: And you've been working with Junior Mance recently?

KB: Yeah. On the cruise things. We did recording in New York and we were on a cruise last year and we are on again this year.

MR: How do you like those cruises?

KB: I love it for the point of getting away from the world you know. At least you're out there for a week and nobody's going to call you and say can I do this, can I do this? But they're going to do it anyhow. No traffic, and everybody's out there for one thing, for the music. But it's just good to see another part of the world, which is water, which I love because I'm under the water sign, and it's refreshing. It's charging the batteries. And you'll get ready to come back and as soon as you get off the ship — okay.

MR: It all descends on you again.

KB: Here comes all the hectic stuff, but I can handle it now.

MR: What's your opinion on where the jazz scene is now as compared to when perhaps in the '50s, '60s.

KB: Well it would be the same opinion as musicians had in the '50s and '60s who came up in

MR: I like that.

KB: They had, from the '20s, well you can go back to say 1910 and start coming up and it started changing there, and then it started getting more sophisticated and more educated with the like Fletcher Henderson, and that came along and then all of a sudden bebop came out and that came for a while and so forth and then another form came, and it's the same — to me it's the same as food. I always say food and music are very similar. Food is for nourishment of your body, and music is for nourishment of your mind. Now if we were to stay with the same food forever, say meat and potatoes and that's it, you know. You'd have meat and potatoes and so forth. But we see how food has changed in the last 50 years as we become more sophisticated. And reach out to more people in various ways. And you've got the dietitians, you've got this, you've got that and so forth. And food is there to supplement the bodies, and the music is doing the same thing to supplement the mind.

MR: That's great. At 8:30 in the morning.

KB: Oh, listen, I could be playing golf.

MR: How's your golf game these days?

KB: Well it hasn't been too good because the weather in Washington this last six months has been unbelievable.

MR: We're from up north too, so it's a pleasure to be down here. They're calling it cold you know, but we can live with that.

KB: What do they know about cold weather?

MR: What's coming up in the future for you? You've got the cruise.

KB: Well just doing a lot of private festivals, kind of like this and so forth. And in the Washington area I've been for the last 27 years doing schools, with a trio. It started — this lady, Evelyn Audvin just started me off one day, "I hear you have some kids in school, you just moved to Maryland, and so if you've got as many kids as they say you have, you must be nice to kids." Well that's got nothing to do with being nice, I mean I know how to get 'em. But she asked me to take the bass and go to a school up county in Montgomery County and I went up there. She picked me up and I went up, and she said, "you know if you could put some kind of program together, I could see you work up something for you to perform for the kids. So I got a piano player and a drummer and we started doing it. And through trial and error, because I always figured in order to deal with kids you have to be, you actually have to be a part of them. And so instead of talking IN to a kid and pushing down on him, PULL from him, and say what is this? You know this is called a bass fiddle. How do you think I would play this? And so I'm pulling.

MR: Let them—

KB: Right. I say this is a bass fiddle and ba, ba, ba, ba, and that's that. They get that with grown ups, with the parents, they get that with the teachers. "Which finger should I play this with?" And so it escalated and I'm doing about a hundred schools in the Washington area, that's with Washington but I also do a Head Start, and I've been out there since '81. I do about 36 a year. And this is Wolf Trap I'm talking about.

MR: Right. And you deal with pretty young kids too.

KB: Three to five. Head Start. And then in Washington Performing Arts and doing the elementary schools in PG County, and sometimes PG County schools start at 8:00 and at 8:30 in the morning you've got to be 30 miles away. But when you walk in and you see these little eyes there, and you're giving them something up close. And then the main thing is participation. Not just plain pushing, get them involved, and then they have an idea of what music is about aside from what they hear, and what's force fed to them by the radios.

MR: Very important.

KB: Yeah.

MR: And it's hopefully setting some seeds in their heads for the future.

KB: We've had some very good results, some talented kids, and I'm speaking of like grade, and junior high. Senior high I just try to do mainly workshops because by the time they get up there they're opinionated for what they want so when they have bands and choruses and so forth we do workshops for senior high and sometimes middle schools.

MR: That's a tough age sometimes, especially in large groups. The little kids are—

KB: I go to some schools sometimes they've got twelve thousand. You know and middle school, gee whiz.

MR: Wow. Well this has really been fascinating. I'm so glad that we were able to have you come over and join us. You are playing today again?

KB: Today, yes. I'm doing the Kansas City Seven, and then the big band, The Juggernauts.

MR: Did you have occasion to play in Kansas City?

KB: Oh yeah. With Dinah, with Bostic, I mean those were dances, but with Dinah Washington we would play. We'd do some one-nighters and we did work a club that was called the Blue Orchid or the Orchid Room or something. Yeah I liked Kansas City. It was a swinging town.

MR: I think there's a movie coming out about it now or something.

KB: Really? All the major cities, Kansas City, Chicago, was whew, oh boy. just — New Orleans, L.A., they was all over then. Because you see you're looking at Washington was a big mecca. But you see at that time people lived in pockets, so everything that was within that pocket flourished, the stores and shops and everything. When the suburbs

patrons started moving out. But once you get 15 miles out of town and you go to work, you don't feel like coming all the way back in. And this is how, to a certain point, some of the patrons was lost because people were expanding their lives and in expanding their lives they was also expanding the distance from what they were from. And so consequently what happened is that then the clubs had to wait for the new people to come in and the new people were not actually seasoned veterans of jazz yet, they had to convert them. But the advantage, the thing that's helping that has been the colleges and with the various, all the music that's going on at colleges, and educating the kids there, then they're starting to get the younger crowd.

MR: I had one last question. When you were playing dances like with Dinah Washington or with Bostic, were these segregated clubs or how did they work?

KB: The dance halls in the south?

MR: Yeah.

KB: Oh yeah, they were segregated. They put a rope up.

MR: They put a rope down the middle.

KB: Not down the middle, down the side. They made the nucleus of it for the blacks to dance, and they'd have a rope on the side, and they'd cut the rope. And the kids back then, they'd put up another rope, and after they'd cut the rope and they'd be out. I mean this was all the time. Because that's when I really got a chance to look at that whole situation and I'm not looking at the political side, I'm looking at the musical side, that these people enjoyed this music and wanted to be a part of it. But they were the ones that were being denied. I mean to a certain point it was the reverse. They were being denied the privilege of just being able to stand and look. But how can you stand in middle, and everybody's out there having fun, and don't move—

MR: Stand behind the rope?

KB: They'd cut the rope.

MR: Very interesting.

KB: Well that was at the time. And it just showed you that, like I said how powerful music is. Because if you check out Shakespeare, if I can remember what it was, Shakespeare, talking to the daughter in "The Merchant of Venice," and you'll find a part in there, I'm trying to figure what chapter it is, but he's telling his daughter he says, "pity the poor man who has no music within his soul, for this person is guilty of treason." And he goes on to elaborate about the person who has no music within him. And you check that out. You'll find it most interesting. And I use this at times when I'm at conferences or something, about being wary about people who really don't have a deep feeling within themselves for music because they are like Shakespeare says, guilty of treason. And it's

hundred years whenever archeologists, wherever they go and they find they discover ruins from the most primitive tribes to the most sophisticated and advanced, they always find some form of art, dance and music, which means that the human being has always entertained themselves, from the very beginning.

MR: And that's the things that we leave for the next generations.

KB: All the generations to come. Because you still want to do something with your hands. He's doing something with his hands. He could have it automatically, even if he just sits there and doesn't touch it. But he wants to be a part of it.

MR: Right. Fascinating. You've given me some things to think about for the whole rest of the day.

KB: Well that's why I'm older than you.

MR: Well I liked your philosophy about wanting to see as much sunlight as you could and that's why you get up so early every morning.

KB: Listen, if I'm home usually I pick up the paper and look at the obituaries, and if I don't see my name, I get up and go do something.

MR: All right. Well, Keter Betts, it's been a real pleasure having you join Hamilton College.

KB: Well thank you.

MR: I hope the rest of your weekend goes very well.

KB: And I would like sometime in the near future, if possible, if you have anything musically up that way, you know, even talks or whatever, to come up there.

MR: We're planning on it actually, we're planning some things, and I'd love to have you.

KB: Is that a threat or a promise?

MR: That is a promise. And when you get there it might turn out to be a threat, I don't know. Thanks so much.

KB: Well thank you.